Who Is My Neighbour?

Jesus turns the question "Who is my neighbour?" into "Will I be a neighbour?", calling us to show mercy to anyone in need, across every boundary.

Main passage	Luke 10:25-37 (KJV)
Topic	Neighbor
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: The question behind the question	7 min
Teaching point 2: Mercy crosses every boundary	7 min
Teaching point 3: Go and do likewise	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "Who are the people you find it hardest to help or to love?" (Do not ask for names; ask for kinds of people.) Then point out that the lawyer in today's story asked Jesus where the edges of his duty were. Jesus answered with a story that removed the edges.

Scripture (3 min)

Luke 10:25-37

[25] And, behold, a certain lawyer stood up, and tempted him, saying, Master, what shall I do to inherit eternal life? [26] He said unto him, What is written in the law? how readest thou? [27] And he answering said, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy strength, and with all thy mind; and thy neighbour as thyself. [28] And he said unto him, Thou hast answered right: this do, and thou shalt live. [29] But he, willing to justify himself, said unto Jesus, And who is my neighbour? [30] And Jesus answering said, A certain man went down from Jerusalem to Jericho, and fell among thieves, which

stripped him of his raiment, and wounded him, and departed, leaving him half dead. [31] And by chance there came down a certain priest that way: and when he saw him, he passed by on the other side. [32] And likewise a Levite, when he was at the place, came and looked on him, and passed by on the other side. [33] But a certain Samaritan, as he journeyed, came where he was: and when he saw him, he had compassion on him, [34] And went to him, and bound up his wounds, pouring in oil and wine, and set him on his own beast, and brought him to an inn, and took care of him. [35] And on the morrow when he departed, he took out two pence, and gave them to the host, and said unto him, Take care of him; and whatsoever thou spendest more, when I come again, I will repay thee. [36] Which now of these three, thinkest thou, was neighbour unto him that fell among the thieves? [37] And he said, He that shewed mercy on him. Then said Jesus unto him, Go, and do thou likewise.

Read the passage aloud, with a narrator, the lawyer and Jesus.

Background (5 min)

The lawyer was an expert in the law of Moses. He tested Jesus with the greatest question: "What shall I do to inherit eternal life?" Jesus let him answer from the law: love God with everything (Deuteronomy 6:5) and your neighbour as yourself (Leviticus 19:18). Then the lawyer, "willing to justify himself," asked, "And who is my neighbour?"

The road from Jerusalem down to Jericho dropped steeply through rocky desert and was notorious for robbers. The priest and the Levite were religious professionals. Samaritans and Jews despised each other; John 4:9 says the Jews had "no dealings" with them.

Teaching point 1: The question behind the question (7 min)

The lawyer wanted to know how small his circle of duty could be. "Who is my neighbour?" can be a way of asking, "Whom am I allowed not to love?" Jesus does not answer with a definition. He tells a story that exposes the question.

Supporting verses

Luke 10:25-29 (read from the Bible)

Leviticus 19:18: Thou shalt not avenge, nor bear any grudge against the children of thy people, but thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself: I am the LORD.

Matthew 22:37-40: Jesus said unto him, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind. This is the first and great commandment. And the second is like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself. On these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets.

> *"Many ask good questions with a design rather to justify themselves than to inform themselves"*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Luke 10:25-37

> *"Desirous to appear blameless, or to vindicate himself, and show that he had kept the law."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Luke 10:29

Handout blanks (answers)

He, willing to **justify** himself, said, "And who is my neighbour?"

"Who is my neighbour?" can mean, "Whom am I allowed not to **love**?"

Teaching point 2: Mercy crosses every boundary (7 min)

The priest and the Levite saw the wounded man and "passed by on the other side." We are not told why; perhaps fear, hurry or religious rules. Then came a Samaritan, the last person the audience expected to be the hero. He "had compassion," and it cost him: his oil and wine, his donkey, his time, his money, and a promise to pay more.

Supporting verses

Luke 10:30-35 (read from the Bible)

Galatians 6:10: As we have therefore opportunity, let us do good unto all men, especially unto them who are of the household of faith.

1 John 3:17-18: But whoso hath this world's good, and seeth his brother have need, and shutteth up his bowels of compassion from him, how dwelleth the love of God in him? My little children, let us not love in word, neither in tongue; but in deed and in truth.

> *"to show that he was a person from whom a Jew had no right to expect any help or relief"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 10:33

> *"the wine to cleanse the wounds, the oil to assuage their smartings"*
> — David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 10:34

Handout blanks (answers)

The priest and the Levite passed by on the other **side**.

When the Samaritan saw him, he had **compassion** on him.

Teaching point 3: Go and do likewise (7 min)

Jesus ends with his own question: "Which now of these three … was neighbour unto him?" The lawyer could not bring himself to say "the Samaritan," only "he that shewed mercy." Jesus replied, "Go, and do thou likewise." The question is no longer "Who qualifies as my neighbour?" but "Whom can I be a neighbour to?"

Supporting verses

Luke 10:36-37: Which now of these three, thinkest thou, was neighbour unto him that fell among the thieves? And he said, He that shewed mercy on him. Then said Jesus unto him, Go, and do thou likewise.

Micah 6:8: He hath shewed thee, O man, what is good; and what doth the LORD require of thee, but to do justly, and to love mercy, and to walk humbly with thy God?

James 2:14-17: What doth it profit, my brethren, though a man say he hath faith, and have not works? can faith save him? If a brother or sister be naked, and destitute of daily food, And one of you say unto them, Depart in peace, be ye warmed and filled; notwithstanding ye give them not those things which are needful to the body; what doth it profit? Even so faith, if it hath not works, is dead, being alone.

> *“Turning the question from, "Whom am I to love as my neighbour?" to "Who is the man that shows that love?"”*
>
> — David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 10:36

> *“It is the duty of every one of us, in our places, and according to our ability, to succour, help, and relieve all that are in distress and necessity”*
>
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Luke 10:25-37

Handout blanks (answers)

He that shewed **mercy** on him was neighbour.

Go, and do thou **likewise**.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why do you think Jesus made a Samaritan the hero of the story?

To shatter the lawyer's limits; mercy can come from the least expected person, and must go to anyone.

2. What reasons might the priest and Levite have had for passing by? What reasons do we give?

Fear, hurry, ritual purity, "someone else will help." Today: busyness, danger, not my problem, discomfort.

3. What did the Samaritan's mercy cost him? What does mercy usually cost us?

Time, money, comfort, risk, inconvenience.

4. Who are the "wounded travellers" in our community, and how could our class be a neighbour to them?

Answers will vary: lonely elderly, refugees, families in crisis, the sick, the poor.

Application (3 min)

This week, look for one person in need whom you would normally "pass by," and stop. Offer practical help: a meal, a ride, a visit, or your time. As a class, consider one way to show mercy together this month.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord Jesus, you crossed every boundary to rescue us when we were wounded and helpless. Forgive us for passing by on the other side. Give us hearts of compassion and hands willing to help, whatever it costs. Make us neighbours to everyone in need, so that we go and do likewise. Amen.

Sources quoted

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Luke 10:25-37

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